

Rebels in Denial: How Armed Groups Respond to Accusations

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Abstract

Armed groups across the international system frequently face accusations made by other actors about their conduct, internal workings, and external ties. Rather than remain passive actors following such claims, armed groups discursively fight back. They frequently do so through public denial statements. Existing research has shed critical light on militant communication strategies, including why armed groups issue threats and claim responsibility for acts of violence. However, current scholarship predominantly examines communication that armed groups proactively initiate on their own terms. Less research has, consequently, focused on reactive messaging in which others' claims set the occasion and subject of communication. As a form of reactive messaging, we outline the characteristics surrounding armed group denial statements and develop a typology of "rebel denials." This typology is based on the kind of reputational injury an accusation inflicts (moral or political) and levels of third-party adjudicability, which denotes whether anyone besides the accuser and the accused can settle the disputed fact. From this typology, we discuss four ideal types of rebel denials: exculpation, reinterpretation, reassurance, and temporization. We then illustrate how jihadist, left-wing, and ethnonationalist groups have utilized these different types of denial statements across numerous conflict zones. This analytical essay enhances our understanding of militant communication strategies and how armed groups contest rival narratives through denial statements. In doing so, we identify new directions for future research on an understudied yet important dimension of militant discourse.

Keywords: denial; reactive messaging; communication; rebel groups; civil wars

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Introduction

Armed groups across the international system frequently face public claims made by other actors about their conduct, internal workings, and external ties. In 2004, for instance, media reports stated that the Movement of Democratic Forces of Casamance (MFDC) in Senegal had relied on child soldiers to augment its fighting forces (Africa News 2004). In the Philippines, the military blamed the Bangsamoro Islamic Freedom Fighters (BIFF) for a deadly bus bombing in the Bukidnon province in December 2014 (de Vera 2014). In another case, the Department of State Services in Nigeria alleged that the Indigenous People of Biafra (IPOB) killed five civilians and hid their bodies in a nearby forest during April 2016 (Ugwu 2016). In August 2022, Israel accused Palestinian Islamic Jihad (PIJ) of launching rockets that struck the Jabaliya and Bureij refugee camps (BBC Monitoring Middle East 2022). More recently, U.S. officials claimed in 2025 that the United States had attacked a suspected drug trafficking boat linked to the National Liberation Army (ELN), implicating the Colombian organization in the drug trade (Burchett 2025). Rather than mere cheap talk, such public accusations can significantly harm the normative and political standing of armed groups. How do armed groups respond to such claims?

An established body of conflict research examines the dynamics surrounding armed group communications strategies. In doing so, scholars have analyzed how and why militants claim responsibility for acts of violence (Hoffman 1997; Min 2013; Abrahms and Conrad 2017; Kearns 2021; Onder 2023), deploy threats against their adversaries (Chiluwa 2017; Brown 2020; Johnson and Gillooly 2023), construct identities and frame grievances (Winter 2015; Re 2020), and practice public diplomacy in pursuit of external support and recognition (Coggins 2015; Jones and Mattiacci 2019). Recent research has also shed critical light on how armed groups amplify their voice across different digital platforms (Zeitsoff 2017; Loyle and Bestvater 2019; Walter and Phillips 2025). These studies often treat rebel communication as proactive: the group chooses what to address, when to speak, and how to frame its messaging largely on its own terms. While environmental factors may affect militant discourse in various ways, armed groups can claim credit for violent attacks, issue threats, construct their identity, and use different means of disseminating propaganda largely when and how they see fit.

Despite shedding critical light on multifaceted aspects of armed group communication strategies, existing scholarship has often overlooked the reactive side of militant discourse. Reactive messaging occurs when armed groups respond to reports, rumors, or allegations made

by governments, rival non-state actors, the media, or international actors about the organization. Put differently, instead of choosing when to speak and about what topic, the occasion and subject of reactive messaging are set by claims made by others about the armed group. Rather than remain passive actors after public claims made by other actors, armed groups often discursively fight back as they seek to influence public perceptions. They frequently do so through denial statements. In each of the cases mentioned above, the MFDC, BIFF, IPOB, PIJ, and ELN all issued statements explicitly denying their organization's involvement in the alleged activities.

This essay develops a framework for understanding denial statements as a form of reactive messaging in militants' communication strategies. In doing so, we develop a typology of rebel denials based on two aspects stemming from the accusations armed groups face. The first concerns the kind of injury, or reputational costs, at stake for armed groups. *Moral injury* arises when the alleged conduct violates normative standards established by the organization, which, consequently, threatens the armed group's legitimacy and moral standing within a community. *Political injury*, by contrast, arises when the allegation does not necessarily imply any normative wrongdoing by the group; rather, it portrays the organization as being weak, incompetent, untrustworthy, or internally divided. The second feature we consider is the accusation's *third-party adjudicability*: whether an actor besides the accuser or accused can plausibly establish whether the disputed fact actually occurred. Adjudicability, we argue, is shaped by both the disputed fact and the information environment in which the fact is contested. Together, these dimensions produce four ideal types of denial statements: exculpation, reinterpretation, reassurance, and temporization. Each reflects a different reason for discursively responding to an accusation rather than remaining silent or claiming responsibility for an action. We illustrate the characteristics of these different categories by drawing on anecdotes of denial statements issued by armed groups with varying ideological beliefs operating in conflict zones across the world.

Focusing on armed group denial statements contributes to the study of political violence and conflict in multiple ways. First, existing research details various tactics and strategies, such as providing effective governance and reducing violence against civilians, that armed groups pursue to legitimize their struggle to internal and external audiences (Duyvesteyn 2017; Loyle et al. 2022; Florea and Malejacq 2024; McWeeney, Cunningham, and Bauer 2025). Focusing on militants' reactive communication builds on the literature on rebel legitimacy-seeking strategies by examining how groups can use denials to combat narratives aimed at delegitimizing their

struggle. Highlighting the importance of winning the battle of narratives, Ayman al-Zawahiri, al-Qaeda's former leader, summarized in an internal document that "we are in a battle, and that more than half of this battle is taking place in the battlefield of the media" (Ensor 2005).

Additionally, research on civilian victimization shows that armed groups often restrain their violence in conflict zones, limiting the use of force against local populations (Stanton 2016; Garbino 2023). Aside from the use of violence, reputations for restraint, especially towards civilians, may be produced discursively as well as behaviorally. Rather than rush to claim every violent attack, denial statements underscore armed groups' attempts to present themselves as restrained actors in conflict zones. Finally, the study of denials extends the literature on "information warfare" in civil conflicts. Uncertainty is a central feature of conflict zones, and armed groups devote significant time and resources to rhetorically justifying their actions and goals (Snow and Byrd 2007; Page, Challita, and Harris 2011; Termeer and Duyvesteyn 2022; Ying 2026). Studying militant denials helps illuminate how wartime discourse is a multilayered contest of competing narratives between armed groups and their adversaries within strategic environments characterized by ambiguity surrounding the power, resolve, and trustworthiness of militant organizations and states (Kydd and Walter 2006).

The rest of this article proceeds as follows. The next section synthesizes scholarship on militant discourse, identifying five clusters of research and their shared "proactive bias." Next, we outline our framework's two primary dimensions, *reputational injury* and *third-party adjudicability*, before presenting the typology. Drawing on this typology, we then illustrate how numerous armed groups have utilized different types of denial statements in their discourse. We conclude by identifying directions for future research on denial statements in conflict.

Existing Research on Rebel Discourse: The Proactive Bias

Violence serves as a form of propaganda for armed groups, sending powerful signals to different audiences. Alongside violence, however, armed actors across diverse contexts devote scarce time and resources to the discursive side of their propaganda. As Brown (2020, 5) notes, militants "cannot achieve their coercive goals by force of arms alone; they must also employ the force of words" as they attempt to "manipulate others' behavior and beliefs." An established body of literature in conflict research examines multifaceted aspects of militant rhetoric. This research area can be organized into at least five overlapping yet distinct clusters.

First, a prominent strand of scholarship interrogates the factors that influence why groups claim responsibility for acts of violence (Hansen 2021). This line of inquiry typically models the communicative choice that follows an attack as one between claiming responsibility and remaining silent. Within that framework, various studies have highlighted the importance of competition between armed groups (Hoffman 2010; Kearns 2021; Hansen 2023), the target and lethality of attacks (Min 2013; Abrahms and Conrad 2017), recent leadership losses (Onder 2023), and geographical factors for understanding whether armed groups claim credit for violent attacks (Hansen and Lemb 2025). Through claiming responsibility for violence, these studies contend that armed groups can generate publicity, signal their capacity to achieve organizational goals, and underscore their resolve. Due to such benefits, some organizations even claim responsibility for attacks they did not commit (Kearns, Conlon, and Young 2014).

In addition to credit claiming, another area of research examines threats issued by armed groups. Threats, like claims of responsibility, are among the instruments with which militants project their intentions and capabilities to disparate audiences. Brown (2020), for example, explores the variation among such threats, outlining how armed groups employ threats to aggrandize their reputations, attain political legitimacy, gain advantages over counterterrorist opponents, disrupt the state's economy, and attain social control among civilians. In another case, Chilwa (2017) analyzes online statements issued by Boko Haram and Ansaru in Nigeria, finding that their threats rarely take the conditional form of ordinary threats, in which the audience's compliance with the armed group averts future violence. Instead, the threats issued by these organizations often present violence as retaliation for wrongs already committed. Outside of Nigeria, Johnson and Gillooly (2023) also detail a "grammar of threat" that is utilized by criminal groups in Colombia and Mexico towards their agent, target, and constituency.

A third cluster explores themes within armed groups' discursive framing efforts. Various studies have also explored specific themes surrounding victimhood (Winter 2015), territorial loss (Kaczkowski et al. 2021), gender (Termeer and Duyvesteyn 2022), resistance (Margolin 2022), and heroism within militant propaganda (Welch 2018). Often drawing on insights from social movement theory, this research area provides key insight to armed groups' framing of grievances, blame attribution, organizational enemies, and strategies for achieving long-term goals (Snow and Byrd 2007). In doing so, scholars have reviewed multifaceted primary sources

published by armed groups, ranging from organizational communiques, magazines, and videos to social media posts (Page, Challita, and Harris 2011; Re 2020; Ying 2026).

An additional line of inquiry connects public communication to rebel diplomacy. Armed groups pursue external recognition by creating participatory institutions, avoiding violence against civilians, and providing services like justice, security, and healthcare (Mampilly 2011; Arjona 2016; Stanton 2016; Stewart 2018; Cunningham, Huang, and Sawyer 2021; Albert 2022). However, communication also plays a vital role. The National Transitional Council (NTC) in Libya, for instance, pursued public diplomacy through the use of social media to garner international support (Jones and Mattiacci 2019). Other groups, ranging from the secessionist National Movement for the Liberation of Azawad (MNLA) to the jihadist Ansar Dine of Mali, have similarly relied on “digital talk” in their diplomatic efforts (Bos and Melissen 2019). As Coggins (2015, 99-100) observes, “whether to mitigate uncertainty or insecurity, to signal intentions or resolve, or to create or maintain successful cooperation, strategic communication is crucial to international relations: This communication occurs via three principal modes: The use of force, the use of money, and the use of talk.”

A fifth cluster explores how the spread of digital platforms has amplified rebel communication over recent decades. During the civil wars in Syria and Iraq, for instance, jihadist organizations produced significant amounts of online content, with more than 154,000 tweets documented in 2014 alone (Klausen 2015). Between 2011 and 2015, militants in Iraq released hundreds of audiovisual and written propaganda materials on the Internet (Walter and Phillips 2025). By the end of 2017, nearly 40 percent of the world's active rebel groups maintained X (formerly Twitter) accounts (Loyle and Bestvater 2019), some attracting hundreds of thousands of followers and generating significant audience engagement (Bestvater and Loyle 2023). Recent research has also tracked how armed groups increasingly migrate to different platforms, such as Telegram (Prucha 2016), TamTam (Weimann and Pack 2026), and TikTok (Lombardi et al. 2025), as they look for new arenas to propagate their rhetoric. Scholars have argued that such technologies, which allow militants to disseminate their propaganda on an unprecedented scale, have reshaped the nature of civil conflict itself (Walter 2017; Zeitzoff 2017).

Although these literatures differ in the type of questions they examine, militants disseminate messaging largely on their own terms in each research area. This includes the attacks they decide to claim, the threats they choose to issue, the themes they select for their propaganda,

the diplomatic strategies they employ, and the online platforms they maintain. We call this shared orientation the “proactive bias” in the study of rebel discourse.¹ What this proactive bias leaves out is the messaging that armed groups initiate in response to statements made by other actors.² Governments, rival non-state actors, journalists, international organizations, and human rights groups regularly make claims about armed groups: that a group carried out an attack, conducted a massacre, secretly negotiated with the government, recruited child soldiers, received support from a foreign state sponsor, experienced infighting, lost territory, or suffered the loss of organizational leadership. Claims of this kind put armed groups in a different position. Here, armed groups have not chosen the subject or timing of the public exchange of words; they can only decide whether to respond and what to say. As a form of reactive messaging, the following section provides a broad overview of rebel denials and discusses the purposes they serve.

Understanding Rebel Denial Statements

Rebel denials constitute public statements in which an armed group publicly dismisses a claim made by another actor. As a critical aspect of an armed group’s public communication strategies, we follow Hearty (2022, 312) in viewing denial statements as “an active process of meaning making” in which armed groups “publicly issue a statement premised on disclaiming, disowning, or dissociating” from various types of allegations made by other actors. These public denials may come from an armed group’s leadership, spokesperson, media office, or, less frequently, rank-and-file members and be issued through communiqués, audio messages, videos, interviews with the media, or even via social media accounts. While organizational members may “proactively” deny engaging in certain actions before rumors begin or accusations are made, denial statements often follow, and are thus a reaction to, accusations from other actors.

Multiple features distinguish denial statements from other types of militant communication. As is noted above, the occasion and the subject of the statement are set by the accuser rather than by the group. An accusation presents a group with three options: it can remain silent, accept the claim, or deny it. A denial is not necessarily a costless substitute for

¹ A similar imbalance has been identified in research on rebel governance, where scholars long emphasized the rebels’ supply of governance over civilian demand for it (Florea and Malejacq 2024).

² Some work on militant communication does examine more reactive behavior, as when scholars trace how Islamic State propaganda responded to territorial losses (Kaczkowski et al. 2021). But even in these cases, scholars analyze the group’s own propaganda rather than its responses to particular accusations or claims made by others.

silence. For instance, a denial that is later disproven may reduce the credibility of the group's subsequent public statements. Moreover, a denial can draw additional attention to an accusation. Silence, however, has its own costs. An unanswered accusation remains part of the public record. For audiences that rebel leadership strives to persuade, such as rank-and-file members and local supporters, silence can be read as confirmation of the accusation.

Within rebel communication strategies, denials serve various goals. For one, armed groups may use denial statements to cast doubt on their responsibility for certain actions. In addition to denying that an event ever occurred or that the organization was responsible for it, an armed group can also use denials to reinterpret characteristics of the event that differ from the accusation's claims (Cohen 2001; Hearty 2022). Placing an alternative account alongside a rival allegation can raise uncertainty about the group's culpability in undesirable actions (Onder and Berlin 2026). Within their denials, the group might also place the "true" blame at the feet of rivals or even their accuser (Cohen 1996). Moreover, denials can also be used to delay the acceptance of damaging news, giving organizational leadership time to effectively manage hardships. In rebuking various types of accusations, denials can address several audiences at once, ranging from the group's own fighters, local civilians, and the wider ethnic, religious, or ideological constituency the group claims to represent to the media, international organizations, and enemy governments. For example, some denials can reassure rebel members and supporters that the group remains capable, cohesive, and committed to the cause while projecting strength to enemy forces. In sum, armed groups can rely on denial statements to achieve various goals on the discursive battlefield. When accusations are made by governments or state-run media, such denial statements challenge the hegemonic discourses constructed by more powerful state actors about their opponents in conflict settings (Dimitrakopoulou and Boukala 2018). Even when a denial is likely to be disproven, such statements signal that a government announcement alone does not settle the matter, with the group adding its own framing of recent events.

Based on these different functions, previous research has categorized denial statements in multiple ways. Analyzing government responses to human rights reports, Cohen (1996), for instance, distinguishes among three types of denial, which "are all more or less active reactions." Under this framework, there are *literal* denials (e.g., "nothing happened"), *interpretive* denials (e.g., "what happened is really something else"), and *implicatory* denials (e.g., "what happened is justified") (Cohen 1996, 522). Applying these insights to denial statements issued by the Irish

Republican Army (IRA), Hearty (2022) writes that IRA denials can be categorized between *conduct-based*, *character-based*, and *organizational-based* denials. While conduct-based denials constitute denials that the IRA was involved in specific actions that violated “the accepted moral code of a national liberation struggle,” character-based denials rebuked notions that IRA members were motivated by non-ideological goals, such as greed. Additionally, organizational-based denials rejected accusations pertaining to internal IRA dynamics, including intra-organizational disputes (Hearty 2022, 316). We build on this research in multiple ways. In doing so, we contend that armed group denials are shaped by two critical dimensions.

The first dimension is the type of injury an accusation carries for an armed group. For one, an accusation can inflict *moral injury* on an armed group when the alleged conduct or event violates a normative standard held by the organization, challenging its integrity and claims to hold the moral high ground in a conflict (Hearty 2022). Accusations of recruiting child soldiers, committing sexual violence, targeting civilians, conducting war crimes, or engaging in extortion against the very population the group claims to protect are typical sources of such moral injury. If audiences come to believe such accusations, the group’s claims of being an actor entitled to speak for a cause or a community may be significantly weakened. This can be highly consequential for armed groups since the audiences who confer such recognition, such as external sponsors, diasporas, international organizations, or local civilian populations, often condition support on the group’s conduct (Lyall, Blair, and Imai 2013; Salehyan, Siroky, and Wood 2014; Stanton 2016; Levy 2022; Daub 2025; Krick, Petkun, and Revkin 2025).

Whether an accusation inflicts moral injury often depends on its content. Although accusations of conducting acts like civilian massacres would violate the normative standards of the vast majority of armed groups and the audiences that support them, this is not necessarily the case for all acts of violence. For instance, an accusation of attacking a regime military barracks does not necessarily imply any normative wrongdoing for an armed group committed to overthrowing a regime. Yet, an accusation of bombing a marketplace would likely transgress the moral codes established by the groups (Abrahms and Conrad 2017). Accusations involving violent attacks, in other words, are likely to inflict moral injury when there are civilian victims or the conduct of an attack is beyond the pale of acceptable modes of violence within a conflict.

In addition to normative concerns, an accusation may also inflict *political injury*. For one, accusations can threaten perceptions of an armed group’s viability by suggesting that the

organization has suffered major setbacks following the arrest or death of leaders, territorial losses, or the cessation of military operations. Allegations that a group is merely a foreign implant due to its external ties and funding also can threaten perceptions surrounding its autonomy and concerns with local conflict dynamics (Drevon and Haenni 2025). Moreover, accusations can threaten views of an armed group's coherence by suggesting that it is not unified due to internal rifts, defections, or the willingness of leaders to engage in secret negotiations without membership consultation. Accusations arising from violent events can also cause political injury. For one, rumors of organizational violence against other rebel groups can portray the armed group as an untrustworthy ally and potentially lead to reprisal attacks. After all, rebel fratricide forms a central component of civil wars (Gade et al. 2019; Hafez 2020). Additionally, an allegation of violating a ceasefire may signal that the group's leadership is unable to control the behavior of its rank-and-file members (Kolås 2011). In these cases, an armed group can be entirely blameless in the normative sense but suffer damages to its political image. The spread of such claims could affect how audiences assess the group as a political and military actor capable of achieving its stated organizational goals. Overall, various types of claims can portray the armed group as being weak, untrustworthy, internally divided, or the puppet of external actors.

Aside from moral and political concerns, an additional dimension surrounding denials is third-party adjudicability. After all, reliable information is often scarce while disinformation is rife in settings characterized by crisis and conflict (Mahoney 2018; Anderson and Eskandari 2024). This concerns whether the disputed fact can be settled by actors other than the accuser and accused. Importantly, adjudicability is distinguishable from veracity. Veracity is a property of the simple question: "is the accusation true?" In contrast, adjudicability is a property of the disputed fact and the environment in which it is contested. A claim can be true yet highly difficult to adjudicate when it is made. Likewise, a claim can be false but arduous to investigate, a possibility familiar to research on false credit-claiming (Kearns, Conlon, and Young 2014). Across different conflict zones, there is significant variation regarding whether a third party can produce a determination about the disputed events.

As a product of the information environment in which claims and counter-claims are contested, adjudicability is affected by whether the contents of the accusations can be publicly observed and if actors with the access and capacity to investigate conflicting claims are present. *Access* concerns whether anyone can physically reach the place or object surrounding the

dispute. Sites of alleged atrocities against civilians in rural districts, for instance, may be outside the reach of reporters or local civil society groups. *Capacity*, on the other hand, is a matter of whether an actor with the resources and the technical ability to investigate is present, such as UN personnel or human rights organizations. Varying levels of access and capacity affect the types of evidence that can be collected about a particular event. High levels of access and capacity can lead to the collection of vital evidence, such as internal documents, testimonials from civilians or former group members, satellite imagery, and digital forensics, while the collection of robust evidence is unlikely when access and capacity are low for external observers. Media outlets and international organizations also provide varying levels of attention and resources to different conflict zones, which further impacts third-party access and capacity (Sobel, Kim, and Riffe 2020).

Overall, denials are shaped by the kind of reputational injury that the accusation would inflict if audiences believed it as well as levels of third-party adjudicability. Importantly, injury and adjudicability vary independently from one another and both can be assessed when an accusation is made. Together, these dimensions organize the typology presented in the following section.

A Typology of Rebel Denials

The two dimensions yield four ideal types of denial statements (Table 1). The typology distinguishes denials according to how adjudicable the accusation is and the kind of reputational injury involved. Importantly, the same kind of event, such as a violent attack, can fall into different categories depending on what is alleged and the information available to audiences.

We discuss each of the four logics in turn. Importantly, we dichotomize both dimensions for explanatory purposes; however, both injury and adjudicability can vary by degree.³ While acknowledging this point, we show how reputational injury and adjudicability shape the reasons for denying rather than remaining silent or claiming the event, how differences within categories affect the form and language of denials,⁴ and how these patterns appear in actual denial

³ Groups can also try to shape adjudicability themselves by presenting different forms of evidence.

⁴Although we generally focus on cases wherein a particular accusation directed at the group preceded the denial, the four logics we develop can also apply to denials issued in anticipation. Armed groups sometimes deny an accusation before it is formally made, for example when they expect to be blamed for an attack. We believe our typology still applies in these cases. The kind of injury the anticipated accusation would cause and the adjudicability of the

statements issued by rebel groups across multiple regions. Rather than a formal test, the examples are intended to probe the logic of denials generated by various kinds of accusations.

Table 1. A Typology of Rebel Denials

	LOW ADJUDICABILITY	HIGH ADJUDICABILITY
MORAL INJURY	Exculpation Denials after unsubstantiated claims that transgress the group’s moral codes. <i>Goal of Denial:</i> Distance the group from allegations that challenge its normative standing. <i>Example:</i> Responding to al-Shabaab allegations that it had bombed civilian targets in Mogadishu, Hizbul Islam stated: “Our group is not behind the blasts ... We view these sentiments as fabrications, because we can’t attack our own positions” (Africa News 2010).	Reinterpretation Denials after well-sourced claims that transgress the group’s moral codes. <i>Goal of Denial:</i> Reinterpret an event’s meaning to maintain the group’s normative standing. <i>Example:</i> While claiming a major 2024 operation in Burkina Faso, JNIM stressed that “those eliminated in the attack are militiamen affiliated with the Burkinabe army,,” adding that “they are lying when they say they are civilians” (CE Noticias Financieras English 2024).
POLITICAL INJURY	Reassurance Denials after unsubstantiated claims that harm the group’s political image. <i>Goal of Denial:</i> Reassure audiences of the group’s resolve, capacity, or trustworthiness. <i>Example:</i> Aghaly ag Alambo, leader of the Movement of Nigeriens for Justice, denied state television reports in 2008 that his group would disarm and enter Qaddafi-mediated peace talks with the government of Niger (Facts on File World News Digest 2008)	Temporization Denials after well-sourced claims that harm the group’s political image. <i>Goal of Denial:</i> Delay damaging news related to the group’s resolve, capacity, or trustworthiness. <i>Example:</i> Between 2013 and 2015, Taliban officials repeatedly dismissed media reports and government claims that their leader, Mullah Omar, had died as “baseless” (NDTV 2015). In 2015, however, the group admitted that their leader had died in 2013 (BBC 2015).

underlying fact should continue to shape the logic of the denial. The difference is that the group speaks first, giving its own account a chance to circulate before the accusation becomes established.

Logic 1: Exculpation (Moral Injury, Low Adjudicability)

The first logic, exculpation, applies when an accusation causes moral injury but is difficult for third-parties to adjudicate. These accusations often concern organizational conduct such as involvement in violent attacks, looting, or targeting civilians, as well as other forms of behavior that transgress an armed group's normative standards. Claiming the conduct, or even appearing to accept the accusation via silence, risks alienating international actors, diaspora communities, and local populations who may condition their support on organizational restraint toward civilians (Stanton 2016, 2020). After all, an unanswered accusation of committing war crimes or abuse against civilians can remain part of the wartime narratives and potentially resurface later in the organization's history. Exculpation can take two forms: participatory or factual. In its factual form, the armed group denies that the alleged event ever occurred. In contrast, the participatory form denies any organizational involvement in the alleged event. In such cases, responsibility rather than occurrence is in dispute. The participatory form of explication may be especially common in accusations of violence that transgress organizational standards. This is the case since responsibility for attacks often remains unclear in conflict zones. For example, 45 percent of attacks recorded in the Global Terrorism Database (GTD) are listed as "unattributed," meaning that observers could not link the event to a particular group.⁵

Numerous examples from across the international system illustrate armed groups' use of denials for the purposes of exculpation. In 2022, the Kurdistan Workers' Party (PKK) rejected government accusations that it carried out a bombing in Istanbul, Turkey: "It is out of question for us to target civilians in any way" (Reuters 2022). Rather than limiting its response to the incident, the PKK invoked a broader rule of conduct, denying not only responsibility for the bombing but also the underlying moral charge that it targets civilians. A splinter faction of the former Revolutionary Armed Forces of Colombia (FARC-EP) also explicitly denied responsibility for a 2025 attack against a Colombian politician, stating that "the units of the FARC-EP did not plan, order, or execute any action against the politician in question" (Acosta 2025). Following accusations that it executed attacks against churches on Christmas Day in 2011, a Boko Haram spokesperson refuted these allegations by stating that "all Christians in the north [Nigeria] should not panic as Islam prohibits attacks in places of worship and it is haram to

⁵ For additional information, see National Consortium for the Study of Terrorism and Responses to Terrorism, <https://www.start.umd.edu/data-tools/GTD>.

burn or attack a church even during jihad. Our prophet told us, do not attack the innocent, women, children and the old” (BBC Monitoring Africa 2012a). Armed groups also deny engaging in extreme forms of violence, even against targets they might otherwise attack. In 2012, for example, General Hamza Randu of the Mombasa Republican Council (MRC) denied any knowledge of an attack in which a Kenyan police officer was beheaded in Kwale County (BBC Monitoring Africa 2012b). Exculpatory denials are not limited, however, to accusations of violence. Allegations of looting, extortion, or coercive recruitment can inflict moral injury by violating the group’s stated normative standards. In Syria, Liwa al-Islam’s name appeared as a signatory on a statement calling for compulsory conscription. The group, however, denied that it had accepted the idea and announced that it would investigate how its signature had come to appear on the document (BBC Monitoring Middle East 2013).

In denying claims that transgress their moral standards, armed groups often portray the accusation as part of a government effort to shape public opinion against the organization. In response, armed groups can plead with audiences to judge the group’s innocence for themselves. Such dynamics occurred following accusations that the Oromo Liberation Front (OLF) targeted civilians in its operations. As summarized by an OLF leader:

Media manipulation and misinformation has become the trademark of the Ethiopian regime. This is particularly manifested in recent years by repeated and brazen fabrication of events by Ethiopian diplomats to Kenya in matters related to recurrent violation of the country’s northern border and terrorizing the pastoral communities inhabiting the area ... The OLF, in the struggle for the right of self-determination of the Oromo people in Ethiopia, does not condone any operation targeting civilian population and there could be no motive or expediency whatsoever for the baseless allegation made (BBC Monitoring Africa 2006).

In another case, a rebel ambush in South Sudan during April 2013 resulted in the deaths of five UN peacekeepers and seven civilians. South Sudan’s military blamed the South Sudan Democratic Movement (SSDM), an allegation that the group strongly rejected: “Such an accusation is blatantly unfounded and it was designed to tarnish the image of our gallant forces that are fighting to build and consolidate independent institutions which shall safeguard the rule of law, freedoms, and equity in the Republic of South Sudan” (Africa News 2013). In 2023, Sidi Omar of the Polisario Front rebuked allegations that the organization ever targeted civilians during its armed struggle, claiming that “the Polisario Front, based on its values and full compliance with the rules of international humanitarian law, has never targeted any civilians in

its war of liberation against Morocco ... We challenge anyone to prove the contrary” (Agence France Presse 2023).

In addition to government accusations, armed groups also dismiss news reported in international media outlets in their exploratory denials. For example, Boko Haram criticized media outlets following claims it had killed a family member of the organization’s founder, Muhammed Yusuf, in 2011:

We are not happy with the way we were being misquoted and misrepresented in the media especially by the International radio houses like BBC, VOA and Radio France International. Today, we received with shock the unfortunate killing of the family member of our leader Sheik Muhammed Yusuf, but to our dismay we later on heard it on the BBC that we said we were responsible for it. This is unacceptable ... The media houses should know that we have an understanding with the press whom we regard as mediators; but if they don't do their job professionally, we will be compelled to take action on their reporters on ground just the way we take actions on the security agents and other enemies of Islam (Africa News 2011).

Appeals to outside verification are common in exculpatory denials because they are easier to make when verification is unlikely in the near future, since presenting oneself as open to scrutiny carries little risk when there are high levels of uncertainty.

Aside from challenging the source of accusations, armed groups may also place the blame on other actors while denying their participation in events that transgress their moral codes. Doing so may be a useful way to further deflect blame in low-information settings. In Myanmar, state-run newspapers accused the Kachin Independence Army (KIA) of killing a woman and wounding six others in a village. In response, the KIA’s spokesperson stated: “All statements made by the [Burma] government are totally false. The real culprit is the Burma Army,” insisting that soldiers were actually responsible for shelling the village (Karen News 2011). Here, the deaths were not disputed, only who caused them. The group answered the accusation by deflecting blame onto state forces.

Overall, denials aimed at distancing an organization’s participation in particular events may be especially effective where information is hardest to verify, such as rural areas beyond the reach of reporters and human rights organizations. Urban settings are not necessarily excluded, however. As the PKK’s denial after the Istanbul bombing shows, even highly visible attacks can leave responsibility open to dispute. These denials often call into question the accuser’s credentials, invoke codes of conduct against such actions, place the blame on rivals, or invite

outsiders to verify the organization's account. However, when both the event and the group's role in it are well-documented, an outright denial may create more problems than it solves. Groups must respond differently in such cases.

Logic 2: Reinterpretation (Moral Injury, High Adjudicability)

The second logic, reinterpretation, applies when an accusation causes moral injury but is relatively adjudicable. When an event is well-documented and the group's involvement is difficult to dispute, a simple denial can be easily disproved. This can damage the group's credibility, making later denials less persuasive. Even though the act itself cannot credibly be denied, its meaning may still be reinterpreted (Cohen 2001). In such cases, the group can accept that the event occurred and that it was responsible but still reject how others characterize the event. Reinterpretation can take several forms and differ based on what the group concedes. A group may dispute who was targeted, insisting that an operation was directed at soldiers or the police rather than civilians. Armed groups also deny intent, describing civilian deaths as unintended consequences of an otherwise legitimate operation, or acknowledge that its members carried out the act while denying that the leadership planned or ordered it. Reinterpretation thus allows an armed group facing a highly adjudicable accusation to contest particular aspects that remain difficult for outsiders to verify in order to maintain its moral high ground in a conflict.

The response of the Farabundo Martí National Liberation Front (FMLN) to accusations from the United States illustrates how this logic can operate. In 1991, the United States charged that FMLN fighters had shot down a helicopter in eastern El Salvador and then killed the three U.S. military advisers aboard on the ground after the crash. The group accepted that all three men had died but rejected prevailing accounts in public discourse of how they died. In doing so, the group stated in a radio broadcast that one pilot was killed instantly and that the other two died shortly afterward from wounds sustained in the crash. It added that the incident "in no way counters our wish not to attack North American personnel," and that the helicopter had carried no visible insignia while overflying a war zone (Reid 1991). The denial thus conceded the operation had occurred but reinterpreted the attack as one against an unintended target and the deaths as the result of the crash rather than an execution conducted by the group, which could damage the organization's normative standing.

In a similar fashion to the FMLN, armed groups often reinterpret accusations by contesting who is being targeted in their armed operations. For example, Angolan militants attacked the Togo national football team as it traveled through Angola's Cabinda province in 2010. In response, leaders of the Front for the Liberation of the Enclave of Cabinda (FLEC) stated that the players were not the intended target of FLEC's operations: "We are at war with Angola, which occupies our territories illegally. We ordered the attack against the Angolan armed forces and the Togo football team had bad luck. We are at war and anything can happen" (Gow 2010). In another case, the National Congress for the Defence of the People (CNDP) faced charges in 2008 that it had killed civilians fleeing to Uganda from the Democratic Republic of the Congo. In response, CNDP leader Laurent Nkunda proclaimed:

We have not carried out any attacks against civilians, unless they are FDLR combatants who fled towards Uganda because, you know, armed men fled to Uganda taking their arms with them. There are armed men who took off their uniforms and fled pretending to be civilians. If they claim people were killed, that is because they are dead FDLR and Mayi Mayi ... combatants. But we did not attack the civilian population (BBC Monitoring Africa 2008).

Again, military operations conducted by the group were not denied. Rather, Nkunda challenged narratives that challenged his organization's treatment of civilians, charges that could generate backlash among supporters and international audiences. Else, Jama'at Nusrat al-Islam wal-Muslimeen (JNIM) reportedly killed upwards of 300 people in an August 2024 operation in Burkina Faso. While claiming the attack, JNIM stressed that "those eliminated in the attack are militiamen affiliated with the Burkinabe army, which is fighting against the mujahideen," adding that "they are lying when they say they are civilians" (CE Noticias Financieras English 2024). In another case, the Kurdish Democratic Union Party in Syria (PYD) denied holding any political prisoners in 2014. Instead, the organization claimed that any individuals who had recently been detained were arrested for conducting "criminal acts" (The Star 2014).

In addition to targeting certain populations, armed groups may also deny targeting practices against certain spaces that could generate local and international condemnation. For example, rather than deny launching missiles into Saudi territory, the Houthis have repeatedly dismissed claims that they targeted Mecca in their missile attacks against Saudi Arabia, declaring that "the Saudi regime is trying, through these allegations, to rally support for its brutal aggression against our great Yemeni people" (Reuters 2019). In another case, the Kurdistan

Freedom Hawks (TAK) claimed credit for a suicide bombing in Bursa in 2016 aimed at “avenging” recent Turkish security operations. However, the group denied that it planned to target the Bursa Grand Mosque during the operation, stating instead that the female bomber had detonated her charge early “due an accident before she had reached the target that was to be brought to account for the massacres against our people” (Yerepouni Daily News 2016). Responding to accusations surrounding its use of violence in 2020, JNIM reiterated its commitment to avoiding the targeting of public spaces frequented by civilians, such as mosques and churches (Jama’at Nusrat al-Islam wal-Muslimeen 2020). The individual conducting attacks may also carry weight for an armed group’s moral codes. For example, while claiming a 2018 suicide attack on French forces in Timbuktu, JNIM rejected allegations that female operatives had executed the bombings since its doctrine bars women from such operations (Abatan 2018).

Reinterpretation also extends beyond the conduct of force. Accusations of how a battle began, for instance, may be met with reinterpetive denials. Here, a group might accept that fighting is underway while denying that it initiated the conflict, shifting the dispute from the fact of the conflict to who was the instigator. In doing so, armed groups can portray themselves as the victims of rival violence who only used force after being attacked. For instance, in 2006, speaking to Mogadishu’s Radio Shabelle, the Islamic Court Union’s Sheikh Sharif Ahmed stated that the organization had “accepted the ceasefire proposed by elders in north Mogadishu,” declaring that “we are not the attackers who need to stop violence. We were attacked without any reason” (Agence France Presse 2006).

A further form of reinterpretation disputes where responsibility lies within the organization. An armed group may accept that abuses occurred and that its own fighters committed them while denying that the acts were authorized, attributing them to insubordinate individuals rather than as part of the organization’s ideological program. For instance, in 2011, a report issued by Human Rights Watch, which relied on interviews with local civilians, stated that rebel forces had burned down houses believed to belong to regime supporters in Libya and stole supplies from medical facilities after seizing territory. The spokesman for the rebel NTC denied at first that anti-Gadhafi fighters were involved, claiming that the acts had been “carried out by individuals who don’t represent the NTC nor the February 17 revolution.” He acknowledged, however, that such things may have happened by “mistake” and that those involved would be brought to justice if there was sufficient evidence (The Associated Press 2011). Here, the acts are

conceded but remain detached from the organization, with the leadership presenting itself as the enforcer of the moral standards in the community.

Through denials, armed groups can thus reinterpret characteristics of highly adjudicable events in their efforts to maintain moral superiority to rival actors. Such reinterpretations do not necessarily deny an armed actor's participation in events. Rather, these denials discursively challenge alternative accounts that cast doubt on the organization's normative standards. While armed groups often employ denials to combat accusations that cause them moral injury, they also use denials to challenge allegations that portray them as being weak, divided, and untrustworthy.

Logic 3: Reassurance (Political Injury, Low Adjudicability)

The third logic, reassurance, occurs when an accusation creates political injury for the organization. In doing so, the allegation makes the group appear incapable, disorganized, unreliable, or riddled with internal disagreement. For instance, armed groups are often accused of suffering from internal strife, being on the verge of capitulation, or serving as the pawns of external states. At the same time, any evidence of such accusations is likely to remain outside of public view due to the lack of documentation or access to classified intelligence, making adjudicability difficult. In such cases, denials carry relatively low reputational costs for the armed group to issue given they are unlikely to be disproved, at least in the near future. Through denial statements in this category, armed groups can reassure audiences of their continued vitality, cohesion, and credibility (Hearty 2022). In multiparty civil wars, local audiences have reason to support the group they judge to be most capable (Kydd and Walter 2006), entailing that silence can be especially costly following accusations that harm an organization's political image. In contrast, a public denial by the group's leadership can provide organizational members and supporters an official account to bolster perceptions of the group's continued capacity to achieve its long-term goals.

Denials respond to different types of accusations that can dampen an armed group's political image. In some cases, the group is factually correct in such denials. However, in other cases, armed groups may simply be casting doubt on the loss of organizational personnel, reassuring audiences of their continued capabilities in the absence of clear evidence. Armed groups also utilize denials to rebuke accusations of internal issues. For example, Abiel Riing Majak, a senior leader of the SSDM denied reports of internal disputes in 2012: "As far as I am

concerned, we are not divided. The fact that we have unanimously appointed our new leader within a short period of time is, by itself, an indication of the existence of unity within our movement. The movement remains united” (Sudan Tribune 2012a). Addressing a news conference in 2007, Martin Ojul of the Lord’s Resistance Army (LRA) also rejected any notions of internal organizational disputes: “The LRA takes this opportunity to dispel allegations of bad blood, splits or a fighting within the hierarchy of LRA/M or mass desertion by its military men ... To you, people of Uganda, be reassured that there is not split within LRA hierarchy, and that there has been no fight within its leadership” (Xinhua General News Service 2007). In another case, the Oduua People's Congress-Reformed responded to accusations of internal rifts in 2021. In doing so, the group highlighted the consequences of remaining silent following rival accusations: “We, members of OPC-Reformed under the leadership of Comrade Dare Adesope would have just disregarded it [the accusation], but there is a saying that silence means yes, as such in order not to mislead the members of the public, we have come to tell you that there is nothing of such” (The Nation 2021). Elsewhere, the KIA’s Colonel Naw Bu rejected allegations in 2025 that organizational members had defected to the military: “The junta has been using allied militia members to pose as our troops and stage fake defections with weapons. Right now, fighting is ongoing near Chipwi and Pang towns. During this time, the junta is spreading a false narrative that KIA troops have surrendered, defected. It’s pure propaganda, nothing but lies” (Burma News International 2025). Unless splinter groups form or leaders are removed via internal coups, definitively proving such claims is often complex in conflict zones with low levels of media reporting and access.

Although difficult to prove, rumors of secret negotiations with the government can also damage an armed group’s political standing. Such accusations can unsettle group members about the organization’s future trajectory while also suggesting to outside audiences that the group may be losing its fight against government forces. Numerous denials have sought to combat such claims. For instance, the Salafist Group for Preaching and Combat (GSPC) consistently rejected reports that it was considering any amnesty deals or peace negotiations with the Algerian regime. In an April 2004 statement, for instance, Nabil Sahrawi of the GSPC explicitly denied any notion that his organization would lay down its arms and surrender to the “apostate” rulers and “real criminals” in the Algerian war (Salafist Group for Preaching and Combat 2004). For its part, Ahlu Sunna Wal Jama’a dismissed statements issued by Somali politicians in 2016 about

impending peace negotiations: “Ahlu Sunna Wal Jama’a has no intention of talking to the administration in Cadaado given that they have done little to address our concerns” (BBC Monitoring Africa 2016a). Responding to 2016 reports that it had agreed a ceasefire with Malian authorities following mediation with the High Islamic Council of Mali, Ansar Dine reiterated through social media platforms its commitment to waging jihad against “enemies of Islamic law” and not straying from this goal until Mali was ruled by a Shari’a-based governance system. (BBC Monitoring Africa 2016b). These denials thus combat narratives that the group is ready to concede major demands or give up its fight against state forces, intentions that are highly difficult for external actors to observe.

Accusations of covert state sponsorship or affiliation with third-party actors can also threaten perceptions of the group’s autonomy and “authenticity” to local conflict dynamics. While there might be solid proof of such support in some cases, relations between state sponsors and armed groups may be less defined in other cases. In such instances, armed groups issue denials to insist that they are independent and not beholden to the whims of foreign actors. In 2011, for instance, leaders of the NTC in Libya denied that it had “received a single cent from any party,” claiming that the group had “not received a single dollar from any Arab country” (BBC Monitoring Middle East 2011). During a 2012 media interview, the leader of the Sudanese Revolutionary Front declared: “South Sudan does not support us. If the US had been supporting us, Khartoum would not have survived until now” (Sudan Tribune 2012b). Mujahideen-e Khalq also denied receiving any funds from any government in its struggle against the Iranian regime, insisting that it “is an independent movement, standing on its own feet both politically and financially” (Ebrahim 2023). In Syria, the deputy commander of the Free Syrian Army (FSA), Colonel Malik al-Kurdi, claimed that Qatar had not provided any assistance as of January 2012: “I assert that no contacts have been made so far between us and any Qatari side or any other country even though we wish the Government of Qatar will assist us” (BBC Monitoring Middle East 2012a). For its part, the Ituri Patriotic Resistance Force publicly rejected allegations in 2013 that Ugandan military officers were working within the organization to further its goals (BBC Monitoring Africa 2013). Moreover, the Fano in Ethiopia disputed claims that it received Egyptian backing, proclaiming that “there is no link between Fano and Egypt in any way. There is no historical or [any] kind of relations between Fano and Egypt. Only they [the Ethiopian government] know where they brought this from” (BBC Monitoring 2024). Although future

proof of an armed group receiving foreign backing may occur, the strength of such ties is often ambiguous, particularly for audiences outside of a conflict zone.

Finally, armed groups vary in their use of violence against other non-state actors in civil wars (Gade et al. 2019; Hafez 2020). Accusations of fratricidal violence can harm an armed group's political image by casting it as untrustworthy and an unreliable partner in relationships with other actors. Consequently, armed groups may rebuke allegations of violence against other rebels. In a similar fashion to other forms of violence, pinning down responsibility may be challenging. In 2021, for example, JNIM rejected the "false claims that had featured in some media outlets" about its assassination of a former rebel commander in Mali, urging international media to "verify the veracity of information when reporting in order to uphold their [journalistic] integrity and message of relaying the truth with impartiality and professionalism" (BBC Monitoring Africa 2021). Along with other denials in this category, such statements reassure relevant audiences of the group's continued capabilities, resolve, and trustworthiness, dispelling notions that it is internally divided, a puppet of foreign regimes, or an unreliable alliance partner. Yet, armed groups may also issue denials when the evidence behind such accusations is clearer.

Logic 4: Temporization (Political Injury, High Adjudicability)

The fourth logic, temporization, applies when an accusation causes political injury and is highly adjudicable. Groups often deny claims that will be inevitably resolved, such as the death of an organizational leader or a successful government offensive. At first glance, this is the most difficult case to explain. The group responds to a given accusation even though the facts will likely become clear within a short period of time. While changing what the audience believes is unlikely in such scenarios, we suggest that other reasons are at work.

Denials can serve as a coordination device that delays impending political damage for the group. Here, denials can provide the organization with critical time to construct a coherent narrative surrounding political losses. For instance, armed groups often challenge stories surrounding successful government offensives even when there may be evidence to suggest otherwise. In March 2018, the People's Protection Units (YPG) issued multiple denial statements rejecting notions that Turkish-backed non-state actors had advanced on and besieged the town of Afrin in northwest Syria. Yet, major international media outlets reported that the YPG had been ousted from Afrin on March 18, 2018 (Van Sant 2018). Despite testimonial evidence and social

media posts from individuals in the town pointing to the YPG's ousting, the group continued to deny the town had fallen for days (Canberra Times 2018). Importantly, the YPG also contested Turkey's claims about the nature of its withdrawal, arguing that the organization had shifted "from a war of direct confrontation to hit-and-run tactics" in order to "avoid larger numbers of civilian deaths and to hurt the enemy" (Chulov 2018). Here, the notion that the organization had retreated due to the strength of rival forces was challenged and reinterpreted, with the YPG declaring its retreat was tactical and supported its concern for preserving civilian lives.

Hezbollah's participation in the Syrian civil war further illustrates these dynamics. Following the onset of the protests in Syria during 2011, rumors and media reporting indicated Hezbollah's involvement in Syria in support of Bashar al-Asad's forces, claims that could be severely damaging for the organization's political standing in the Arab world given al-Asad's low popularity. Early on, adjudicability was low regarding the organization's involvement, with it being "difficult to verify the validity of these claims. Many of these stories appear in anti-regime media outlets or are based on single-source reporting from opposition sources" (Sullivan 2014, 11). During this time, Hezbollah's denials were largely based on reassurance. For instance, Na'im Qassem, the group's then Deputy Secretary-General, stated in April 2011 that "there are attempts today in Lebanon to [mislead people with] issues such as the existence of Hezbollah fighters in Syria ... Everything they're stating is untrue" (BBC Monitoring 2012). However, levels of adjudicability shifted over time. Formal accusations of the group's involvement in Syria by the United States as well as funerals for Hezbollah members in Syria over the course of 2012 made it increasingly challenging to dispute such claims. However, Hassan Nasrallah, Hezbollah's then-leader, continued to deny his organization's participation in fighting alongside the Asad regime in 2012 (Sullivan 2014). It was only in 2013, after significant expansion of its combat activities, such as during the Battle of Qusayr, that Hezbollah shifted its discourse and readily acknowledged its backing of the al-Asad regime (Sullivan 2014).

Despite evidence to the contrary, armed groups deny the death of organizational members even when those claims are true. Leadership removal forms a critical event in an armed group's history, potentially leading to organizational splintering and significantly reduced operational capacity (Price 2012; Bacon and Grimm Arsenault 2019; Mendelsohn 2024). Delaying news that a leader or organizational members have been arrested or killed through denial statements offers high-ranking officials an opportunity to manage succession and prevent defections before the

situation becomes clearer. An official denial not only challenges rival accounts but also provides the group with time to shape how its members interpret the news. For example, the Taliban has used denials in the face of government claims about the death of organizational members. In 2013 and 2014, allegations surfaced that the Taliban's charismatic leader, Mullah Omar, had died. However, such claims remain unsubstantiated, and actors such as the United Nations continued to treat the Taliban as if it was led by Mullah Omar during this time.⁶ Rebutting such claims, the organization's spokesperson, Zabihullah Mujahid, declared in June 2013 that "[Mullah Omar] is for sure in Afghanistan but we cannot disclose his whereabouts due to security reasons ... The leadership of the Taliban supreme council doesn't allow him to appear in public or speak to the media, as his life is in danger" (Blackwell 2013). Following additional claims from Afghan security officials regarding Mullah Omar's death the next year, Mujahid again proclaimed in November 2014 that Mullah Omar was "alive and active" (BBC Monitoring South Asia 2014). To support these denials, the Taliban published statements attributed to Mullah Omar, expelled senior figures who doubted that he was alive, and even noted that he remains "in touch with date-to-day happenings of his country, as well as the outside world" (Kumar 2023).

After repeated questions about Mullah Omar's whereabouts, however, the Taliban finally admitted in August 2015 that Mullah Omar had died more than two years ago in April 2013. A biography published by Mullah Akhtar Mansour, the successor leader to Mullah Omar, noted the reasons behind the organization's decision to deny their founder's death for more than two years:

Several key members of the supreme leading council of the Islamic Emirate [Taliban] and authentic religious scholars together decided on concealing the tragic news of the passing away of [Mullah Omar] ... and keep this secret limited to the very few colleagues who were already informed of this incorrigible loss ... One of the main reasons behind this decision was ... that 2013 was considered the final year of power testing between the mujahideen and foreign invaders who ... had announced that at the end of 2014, all military operations by foreign troops would be concluded (BBC 2015).

Another account contends that Taliban leaders may have also delayed the news in order to give the leadership time to negotiate with the United States (Lahoud 2022). Coming to the bargaining table following the death of its charismatic founder would have put the group in a much weaker position. Regardless, these repeated denials were likely intended to delay news that would be heavily damaging to the group during a critical strategic moment in the organization's history.

⁶ For instance, see United Nations Security Council, "Letter dated 9 June 2014 from the Chair of the Security Council Committee Established Pursuant to Resolution 1988 (2011) Addressed to the President of the Security Council," June 10, 2014.

In other instances, denials aim to delay damaging news from spreading from a territory which the armed group governs. According to aid agency staff and doctors interviewed by Human Rights Watch, Houthi authorities provided no data or information about the cholera outbreak to the Yemen Health Cluster until March 2024. Several doctors noted that the Houthis actively denied the existence of cholera in the territories they controlled despite doctors sounding the alarm. Despite these denials, authorities later published data proving the existence of cholera in Houthi-governed territories (Human Rights Watch 2024). The Houthis' denial thus did not prevent the acknowledgment of the outbreak; rather, the group delayed damaging news that indicated ineffective political governance from spreading.

Finally, armed groups across the world receive support from state actors (Karlén et al. 2023). Protecting the image of state sponsors may be another consideration of militant denial statements. While armed groups can deny actions that cause their state sponsors political injury in situations of low adjudicability, denials may be particularly important in situations with clear evidence pointing to an armed group's culpability. Such denials can protect the image of state allies, offering them plausible deniability on the international stage. The deadly 2008 Mumbai attacks serve as an example. Despite mounting evidence proving their involvement, Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) repeatedly denied responsibility for conducting the attacks (Ali and Shehzad 2009). On the first anniversary of the attacks, LeT founder Hafiz Saeed stated that he was "extremely saddened by the loss of innocent lives which occurred as a result of the Mumbai attacks," lamenting that India had "deceitfully blamed" him for orchestrating the attacks (Walsh and Ramesh 2009). On one hand, denying the attacks pushed back against notions causing significant normative harm to the LeT due to the large number of civilian deaths in the attacks. On the other hand, denying the attacks provided Pakistan space to also deny any culpability in the violence despite its long-term backing of LeT operations. Put differently, claiming this attack would have caused not only significant moral injury to the LeT but also significant political injury to Pakistan for its backing of an organization labelled as a terrorist group by major international actors. This example highlights the multifunctionality of denial statements depending on the organization's connections to other armed groups and state actors.

Moving Forward: Future Research on Rebel Denials

Denial statements form a critical aspect within the communication strategies of armed groups. This article highlighted that numerous types of ideological organizations, ranging from jihadists to left-wing and ethnonationalist groups, have published denial statements across the world. Yet, there is little understanding of the conditions under which armed groups are likely to publish denial statements, whom their denials most often address, and whether denial statements are effective at achieving disparate goals. In this concluding section, we identify directions for future research on militant denial statements.

Event-Level Data

Testing the logics identified in this essay requires systematic data on denial statements. While research on credit-claiming has often relied on information from the Global Terrorism Database (GTD), there is no current dataset on militant denial statements. Data of this kind will help examine several questions. The first is whether the logic of denial statements follows the kind of reputational injury the accusation inflicts, as our framework expects. Another question concerns whether the form of a denial varies with third-party adjudicability. For instance, reinterpretation and concession may cluster where evidence is readily available to outside audiences. Additionally, event-level data on denials would help to understand how quickly armed groups respond to accusations and whether the interval between accusation and denial differs across the four logics. Finally, further data collection projects could shed light on whether armed groups more often deny that an event occurred or that they participated in it, and whether that distinction tracks the accuser's ability to document the event.

Additional scholarship could also explore the effects of organizational setbacks on militant denial statements. For example, recent research highlights how territorial losses can influence the propaganda output of armed groups (Kaczkowski et al. 2021). While armed groups in relatively strong and stable positions may have little need to combat enemy narratives through denial statements, organizations suffering consistent battlefield losses might be more likely to turn to discourse to bolster their image. In doing so, weaker armed groups may strive to convince local and international audiences of their resilience despite ongoing operational mishaps. Through cross-national data on rebel denial statements, this expectation can be tested directly:

whether groups issue more denials after territorial losses or the deaths of commanders, and whether such setbacks shift a group's denials from focusing on accusations of moral injury toward combating accusations of political injury. Overall, understanding the conditions that affect armed groups' use of denial statements is a key avenue for future research.

Competition in Multiparty Conflicts

Civil wars are frequently fragmented, containing numerous armed groups competing for scarce resources and support (Zech and Gabbay 2016). One condition that may explain why some armed groups deny more than others is competition in multiparty civil wars. In competitive conflicts, armed groups attempt to differentiate themselves from rivals in multifaceted ways to secure local and/or external support (Schwab 2023). Although studies find that competition can drive some armed groups to claim attacks (Hoffman 2010; Kearns 2021), this might only be the case for some militant organizations. After all, armed groups can differentiate themselves from more extreme rivals by exhibiting restraint in their use of violence (Stanton 2016). Attempting to demonstrate their behavioral moderation relative to rivals, armed groups may deny violent attacks, especially those that target civilian populations and violate their commitment to restraint, more frequently than relatively more extreme rivals. If so, competition can serve as an impetus for groups seeking to demonstrate their restraint to deny more attacks.

Focusing on the effects of competition leads to multiple questions. For example, do groups in multiparty conflicts deny accusations of civilian targeting more often than groups that face the state alone, and does the presence of a more extreme rival increase the number of such denials? Which groups respond to competition by claiming and which by denying, and does the difference depend on organizational ideology? Rival non-state actors are also accusers. Future studies could explore if armed groups answer accusations made by rival non-state actors differently from accusations made by governments and whether exculpatory denials place the blame on more extreme rivals. Competition bears on the reassurance logic as well. If local audiences in multiparty wars support the armed group they judge most competent (Kydd and Walter 2006), then denials of splits, defections, and secret negotiations should be more frequent during situations in which a rival stands to gain from the accusation.

The Effectiveness of Denials on Public Perceptions

Another strand of research could examine the effectiveness of denial statements on public opinion. In doing so, future scholarship could examine why and when denial statements are more persuasive in influencing public perceptions in some cases but not others. Experimental evidence highlights that denial statements issued by armed groups can reduce belief in government credibility by raising uncertainty about a group's culpability in violent attacks. If denials work by placing an alternative account beside the accusation, then this effect should be strongest where third-party adjudicability is low.

Relatedly, the effectiveness of denials may be bolstered by the organization being proven correct at the expense of rival actors. In 2015, for instance, the United States claimed that it had killed Mokhtar Belmokhtar of al-Qaeda in the Islamic Maghreb (AQIM) (Reuters 2015). This was one of many instances of a state claiming to have killed the AQIM commander. However, AQIM's denials that Belmokhtar had been killed were repeatedly proven to be correct over time. Additionally, a 2020 UN report claimed that al-Qaeda in the Arabian Peninsula's (AQAP) leader, Khaled Batarfi, and prominent commander, Sa'ad bin Atef al-Awlaki, had been killed in Yemen. In response, AQAP issued a denial statement proclaiming that:

We in al-Qaeda Organization in the Arabian Peninsula, deny this news in whole and in its details, and it is a false and deceptive report and an outright lie to the public. We know for sure that it is a lie, and the enemy knows for certain that it is a lie, and its purpose is to repeat the cycle of lies and broken rumors which have bored the people, and it is a miserable and failed attempt to wage psychological war on the mujahideen ... Then, bring your evidence if you are honest, but you will not find the means to do so (al-Qaeda in the Arabian Peninsula 2021).⁷

In this case, AQAP's denial was factually correct, proving the mistakes of UN reporting. Additional research could probe these dynamics further, exploring how the veracity of denial statements bolsters beliefs in denials and adversely affects the accuser's credibility. On this point, further studies could explore whether an accurate denial raises the credibility of a group's later statements. Understanding these dynamics is key for policymakers who make claims, contend with rebel discourse in contested information environments, and worry about their public perceptions among different audiences.

⁷ This statement, along with the GSPC and JNIM statements listed above, are available at jihadology.net.

Intended Audiences

Armed groups attempt to influence the perceptions of numerous audiences through their discourse. State sponsors, diaspora communities, local civilians, rival armed groups, governments, current fighters, and potential recruits may all respond differently to the same denial statement. The decision to deny an accusation suggests that the group judges it to be damaging enough to respond to, which may be informative in assessing which audiences the group believes it answers to and which standards it believes those audiences apply to rebel conduct. Armed groups that depend heavily on external recognition or seek internal legitimacy, for example, may deny accusations that more locally embedded groups might leave unanswered. Yet, these audiences can be difficult to separate in practice. Especially with the rise of social media and the use of the Internet by armed organizations, denials can easily travel beyond the audiences for which they may have been intended. This raises questions about the trade-offs armed groups face when speaking to several audiences at once.

Research surrounding denial statements and audiences can proceed via multiple avenues. The first is identification. Many denials name their audience, such as when the LRA addressed the “people of Uganda,” allowing the intended audiences to be identified and compared across different denial statements. Further research could also explore whether dependence on particular audiences explains variation in the content of denial. Do armed groups that rely on external sponsors or seek international recognition deny a wider range of accusations and in different terms than groups whose support is more local? The temporization logic raises a related question: when do groups deny on behalf of a state sponsor, and does the sponsor’s exposure predict whether the group denies? The third avenue is associated with trade-offs organizations face through issuing denials. When a denial reaches populations it was not intended for, does the group lose with one audience what it gains with another, and do groups manage the problem by varying the content of their denials according to the audience they most need to reach?

Overall, these agendas can move the typology developed here from a description of how armed groups deny to a set of tested claims about when they deny, whom they address, and what their denials achieve. In doing so, future scholarship on militant denials could provide important insight into understudied aspects of militant discourse and civil war dynamics.

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